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Denver license plate readers have led to early public safety improvements, police say

By **Sage Kelley** June 5, 2024 | updated 2 years ago

55 of the 111 cameras have been installed in the city so far



FILE PHOTO: Denver Mayor Mike Johnston and Denver Police Chief Ron Thomas teamed up at a press conference Jan. 25 to announce a robust effort to crack down on auto theft. "If you're going to steal a car, do it somewhere else," Johnston said. (CarolMcKinley/Denver Enterprise Reporter carol.mckinley@gazette.com <https://denvergazette.com/content/tncms/avatars/5/c3/a0f/5c3a0fbe-1007->



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solve and curb those crimes, according to Denver's officials.

The Automated License Plate Reader pilot network announced by the Denver Police Department earlier this year has already showed improvements in public safety, the department said in a Wednesday news release.

"We know that auto theft can have a huge impact on victims' lives, which is why we tackled this issue head-on with the new license plate reader network," Denver Mayor Mike Johnston said in the release. "The early successes of this program are a testament to DPD's incredible work, and lay the groundwork for our comprehensive strategy to increase public safety and reduce auto theft throughout the city."

The ALPRs, which the Johnston administration unveiled in January, are a set of 111 cameras placed at nearly 70 intersections across the city.

The cameras are activated to help the police department and its Denver Auto Theft Team track down stolen vehicles and identify vehicles wanted in other dangerous crimes, the department said.

The system is said to only capture an image of the back of vehicles and does not film the driver or others inside of the vehicles. That license plate image is then utilized to locate vehicles involved in hit-and-run crashes and vehicles associated with a crime.

Only 55 cameras have been installed so far — with the 111 total coming by the middle of June.

Though only half of the projected total cameras are operational, there have been more than 15 cases where the system resulted in felony arrests or assisted officers and investigators in May, the department said.



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are optimistic about achieving even more positive outcomes like these for our community once the network is fully installed,” Police Chief Ron Thomas said in the release.

Not all Colorado areas adopted the camera technology.

Earlier this year, the Elbert County Commissioners [voted](#), 3-0, against renewing the contract for the region’s nine Flock Safety brand license plate readers, calling the constant surveillance of passing vehicles “Big Brother.”

During a press conference announcing the cameras, Thomas, the police chief, said the city is “not going to be shy about where the cameras are located.”

A map of the camera locations across the city’s six police districts was [released](#) at the time of the project’s announcement.

 FILE PHOTO: Denver Mayor Mike Johnston and Denver Police Chief Ron Thomas teamed up at a press conference Jan. 25 to announce a robust effort to crack down on auto theft.

FILE PHOTO: Denver Mayor Mike Johnston and Denver Police Chief Ron Thomas teamed up at a press conference Jan. 25 to announce a robust effort to crack down on auto theft. “If you’re going to steal a car, do it somewhere else,” Johnston said. (CarolMcKinley/Denver Enterprise)

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